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ForumIAS

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anything in this Area)

Q.3) a) Discuss in detail the approaches to study religion in Anthropology. (20 Marks)

Durkheim in his book, "The Elementary Forms of Religious Life" defined Religion as unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things.

There are different approaches to study the religion in anthropology.

① Evolutionary Approach

It seeks to study the origin of and evolution of religion. Lubbock was the 1st anthropologist to provide the evolutionary sequence of religion.

Lubbock → Atheism → Fetishism → Nature worship
↓
Monotheism ← Polytheism ← Totemism

→ Atheism → No belief in the existence of supernatural powers

→ Fetichism → Belief that certain objects possess supernatural powers.

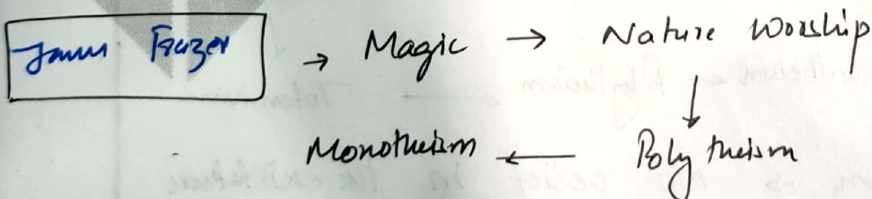
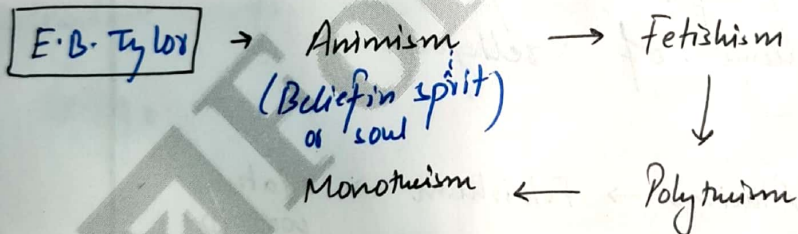
Nature-worship - Forum of nature like Rain, Sun, moon etc are worshipped

Totemism → Different groups associated themselves with objects like plant, animal, birds, non-living objects and called them their Totem.

Polytheism → Belief in multiple Gods.

Monothism → Belief in single God.

→ Other evolutionary sequence are -



→ Acc to Malinowski, religion is an "outlet to frustration". Religion give the confidence to individual to carry out life activities and help them to get rid of their fears.

→ "Radcliffe Brown" said that religion is important for a community rather than an individual. Religion through the concept of sin helps to maintain the social order and ensure the proper functioning society.

→ Durkheim mentioned that Religion promotes intra-group solidarity and it promotes a we-family as the members of a political as religion shares same secular interests.

Among all the approaches, the functional approach seems to be more appropriate.

Feedback

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Structure/
Question
Content
Value
Total